

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Global data (World, 2023) • For public health policy analysts and mental health program planners

Hundreds of Millions Affected

1 in 3 women

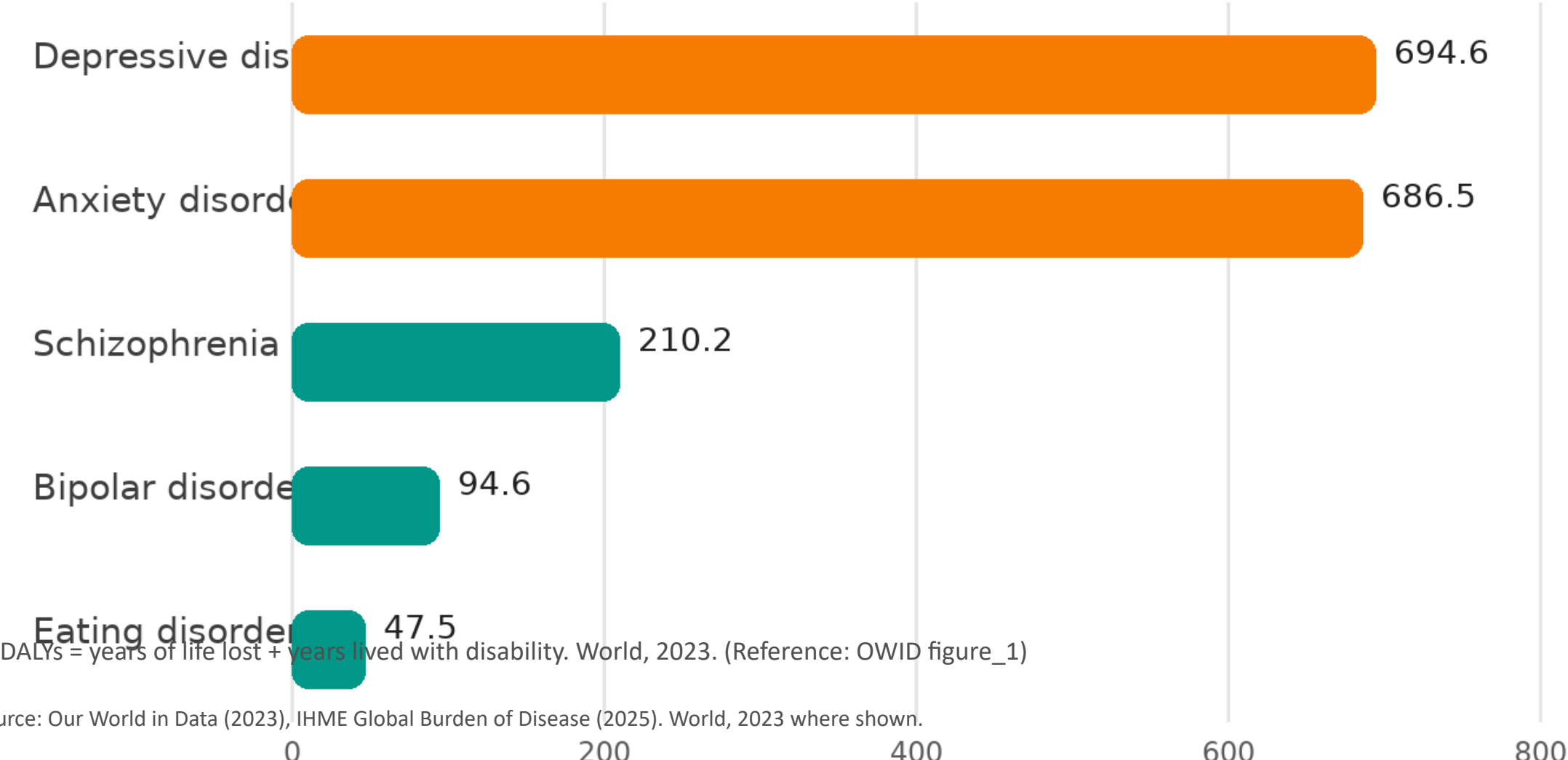
will experience major depression
in their lifetime

1 in 5 men

will experience major depression
in their lifetime

Mental health conditions range from very common (depression, anxiety) to less common but severe (schizophrenia, bipolar).
Policy relevance: large population exposure plus disability impacts health, work, and relationships.

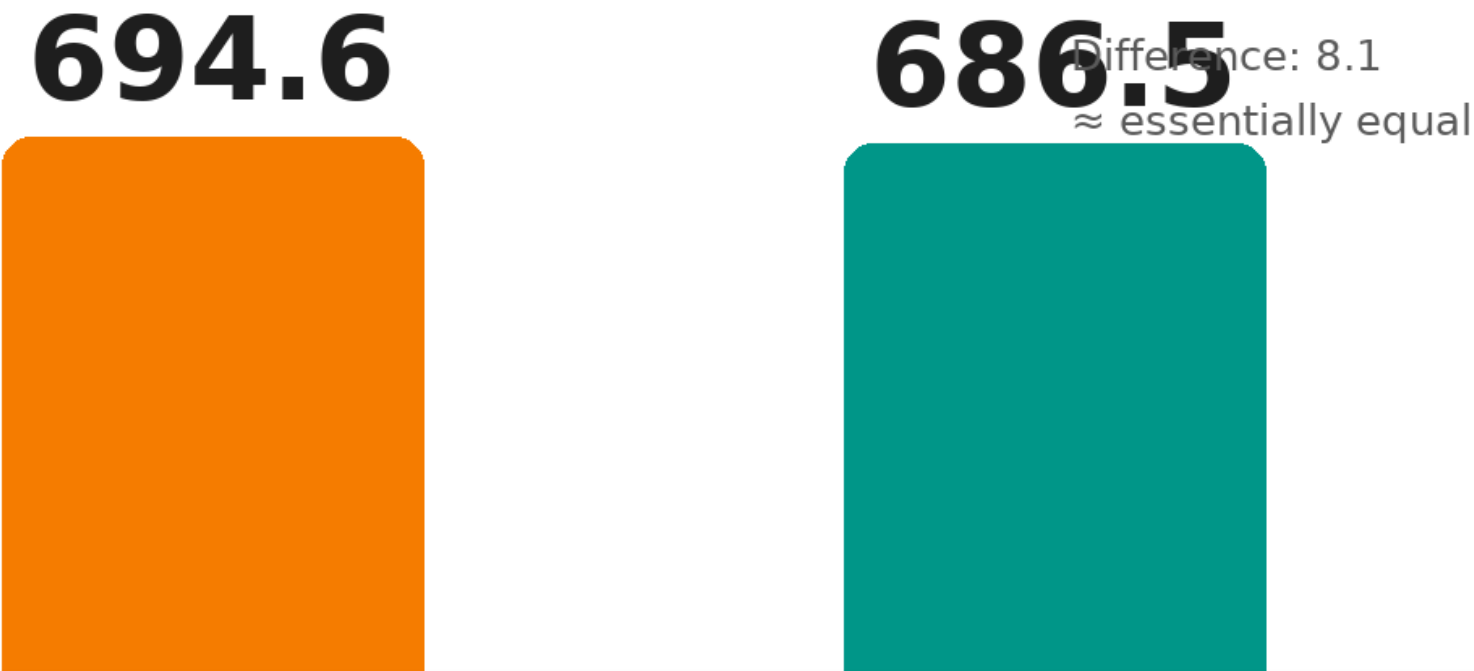
Disease burden by category of mental illness



DALYs = years of life lost + years lived with disability. World, 2023. (Reference: OWID figure_1)

Source: Our World in Data (2023), IHME Global Burden of Disease (2025). World, 2023 where shown.

Near-parity in global burden (DALYs per 100,000)



Depressive disorders (694.6) and anxiety disorders (686.5) have nearly identical DALY rates, together dominating the mental health burden.

Severe Conditions: Lower Prevalence, High Impact

Schizophrenia



210.2 DALYs/100k

Bipolar disorder



94.6 DALYs/100k

Compared with depression/anxiety (~690 DALYs/100k), population-

Policy implication

Maintain specialized care pathways for severe mental illness.
Plan for long-term disability and support needs.
Balance scale-up for common disorders with sustained care for

y disabili

Mental illnesses are treatable, yet treatment is often lacking or of poor quality.



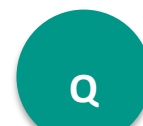
Stigma

People may feel uncomfortable sharing s



Access

Treatment is often lacking, especially in l

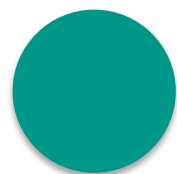


Quality

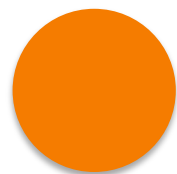
Even where care exists, it may be poor quali

Data challenge: discomfort with disclosure contributes to underreporting, making true prevalence hard to estimate.

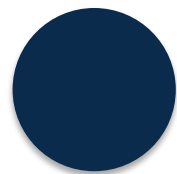
How People Cope



**Prescribed
medication**

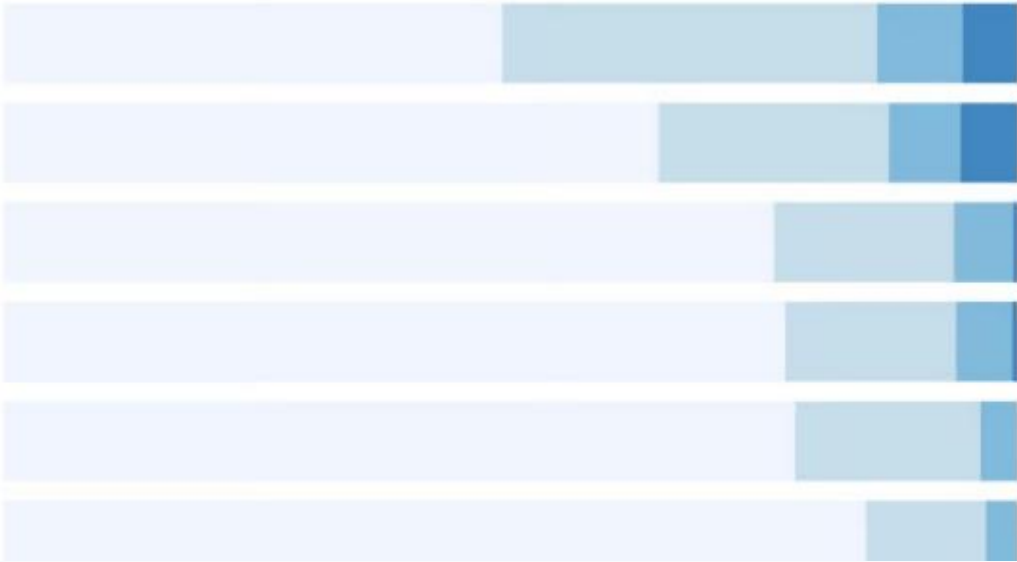


**Religious /
spiritual
activities**



**Talking to
friends or
family**

Global surveys show wide cross-country variation in coping responses.



Reference: OWID figure_2 (coping strategies across countries).

Key Takeaways for Policy

Depression and anxiety are the dominant contributors to mental health DALYs (~695 and ~687 per 100,000). Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder have lower population-level DALYs (210.2 and 94.6) but can be severely disabling. Effective treatment exists, yet access is often lacking and care quality can be poor. Stigma and discomfort sharing symptoms suppress help-seeking and contribute to underreporting. Prioritize scaling evidence-based care for common disorders while maintaining specialized services for severe mental illness.